

Working backward to traffic

Week 8, Lecture 2 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- The three funnel rates and where the benchmarks come from
- Three growth scenarios for LangoBee: community-led, creator-led, loop-led
- Funnel arithmetic: required monthly visitor counts per scenario
- Why 5% monthly churn caps MRR regardless of traffic
- Setting the maximum defensible CAC from each scenario's LTV

The three funnel rates

Rate 1: visitor-to-signup

Where does your visitor-to-signup benchmark come from?

Carter (2024) and RevenueCat (2025) benchmarks for consumer subscription apps:

- Organic/community cold traffic: 2-5% visitor-to-signup typical
- Pre-warmed audience (creator referral, prior list): 5-10%
- CC-required trial: lower end of the cold range, typically 2-3%

LangoBee's CC-required 14-day trial sits at the lower end. A realistic planning assumption: **2-4%** visitor-to-signup for cold traffic.

Direct/Discord traffic (LangoBee's only proven channel) likely converts higher, around 5-10%, because those visitors are pre-warmed.

(Carter, 2024; RevenueCat Research Team, 2025)

Rate 2: signup-to-trial

The gap between signup and trial start is the paywall moment.

RevenueCat (2025): overall median download-to-paid rate is 1.7% at 30 days, with top apps reaching 4.2%. The implied signup-to-trial rate for CC-required trials lands in the 15-40% range when trials convert at the reported 35-40% median.

For a CC-required trial with an early paywall placement:

- Ambitious estimate: 40% of signups start a trial
- Conservative estimate: 15-25%

LangoBee benchmark: zero trial starts from all signups to date (June 2026 snapshot). This rate is the single least trustworthy input in the whole model.

(RevenueCat Research Team, 2025; LangoBee June 2026 snapshot)

Rate 3: trial-to-paid

RevenueCat's State of Subscription Apps 2025:

- CC-required trials: median 35-40% conversion to paid
- Top performers (trials longer than 4 days): above 60%
- Overall download-to-paid in 30 days: median 1.7%, top apps 4.2%

The 35-40% figure applies after a user has started a trial. It does not include the funnel loss from signup to trial start.

Education apps specifically: refund rate 4.86%, which slightly reduces net trial-to-paid.

Planning assumption for LangoBee: **35%** base case, **25%** pessimistic.

(RevenueCat Research Team, 2025)

Three scenarios

Scenario A: community-led

Reddit (r/Spanish, r/languagelearning) and Discord.

Assumed rates:

- Visitor-to-signup: 3-5%
- Signup-to-trial: 20-30%
- Trial-to-paid: 35%

Required monthly visitors:

To generate 63 new paying subs/mo:

- Pessimistic: $63 / (0.03 \times 0.20 \times 0.35) = \sim 30,000$
- Optimistic: $63 / (0.05 \times 0.30 \times 0.35) = \sim 12,000$

Today's baseline: 174 direct visitors/month.

Gap: 70-170x current volume.

Scenario C: loop-led

The shorts share loop: a learner shares a clip, the share drives new visitors.

Assumed rates:

- Visitor-to-signup: 2-4% (cold share context)
- Signup-to-trial: 20%
- Trial-to-paid: 30%

Required monthly visitors:

- Pessimistic: $63 / (0.02 \times 0.20 \times 0.30) = \sim 52,500$
- Optimistic: $63 / (0.04 \times 0.20 \times 0.30) = \sim 26,250$

Today's baseline: 408 shorts impressions, 1 share in 30 days (June 2026 snapshot).

The loop is unvalidated. At current share rates, this scenario requires ~130x more impressions than LangoBee currently generates.

(LangoBee June 2026 snapshot)

Scenario comparison

Scenario	Visitors/mo (pessim.)	Visitors/mo (optim.)
Community-led	~30,000	~12,000
Creator-led	~9,000	~5,600
Loop-led	~52,500	~26,250

Creator-led has the lowest visitor requirement because the channel pre-filters for intent. Community-led and loop-led have lower conversion rates because they reach colder audiences.

None of these scenarios is achievable with LangoBee's current acquisition (174 visitors/month). The model quantifies the gap; the next three weeks identify which scenario closes it fastest.

Why 5% churn caps all three scenarios

Generating more traffic does not change the churn ceiling. At 5% monthly churn:

$$\text{Ceiling} = \text{New subs/month} / 0.05$$

In scenario B (optimistic, 63 new subs/month from 5,600 visitors):

$$\text{Ceiling} = 63 / 0.05 = 1,260 \text{ subscribers} = \sim \$10,067 \text{ MRR}$$

If churn rises to 8% (early cohort typical):

$$\text{Ceiling} = 63 / 0.08 = 788 \text{ subscribers} = \sim \$6,295 \text{ MRR}$$

\$10K MRR becomes unreachable regardless of traffic until churn falls below 5%.

Carter (2024): top-quartile consumer subscription apps retain about 50% of subscribers after year 1 (implied annual churn ~50%, or roughly 6% monthly). Reaching the sub-5% range requires deliberate retention work from day 1.

Maximum defensible CAC per scenario

Community-led CAC estimate:

5 hrs/month founder time at \$50/hr = \$250 total.

At 63 new subs: $\$250 / 63 = \mathbf{\$3.97/sub}$
(slightly above the \$3.66 floor; within the base case \$17.47).

Loop-led CAC estimate:

2 hrs/month at \$50/hr = \$100 total.

At 63 new subs: $\$100 / 63 = \mathbf{\$1.59/sub}$
(lowest CAC, but requires the highest traffic).

Using RevenueCat median LTV of \$10.97 and 3:1 rule: max CAC = **\$3.66**.

Using P90 LTV of \$52.41: max CAC = **\$17.47**.

Creator-led CAC estimate:

\$200 micro-sponsorship per month.

At 63 new subs: $\$200 / 63 = \mathbf{\$3.17/sub}$
(under even the conservative floor).

Winning B2C subscription companies stay radically lean and target one-month CAC payback periods rather than relying on long-term LTV justification to fund growth. (Paraphrased)

Lenny Rachitsky (2022)

How to Win in Consumer Subscription

Take-aways

1. Visitor-to-signup rate is 2-8% for LangoBee depending on channel warmth; signup-to-trial is the least-known and highest-variance rate in the model.
2. Creator-led acquisition requires the fewest monthly visitors (5,600-9,000) to generate 63 new paying subscribers per month.
3. Community-led and loop-led scenarios need 12,000-52,500 monthly visitors, compared to 174 today.
4. 5% monthly churn caps steady-state MRR at $1,260 \times \text{ARPA}$ regardless of how many visitors you generate. Retention work is not a nice-to-have; it is the binding constraint.
5. At the RevenueCat median LTV, the maximum defensible CAC is \$3.66-\$17.47. Creator-led and loop-led scenarios stay within this range; community-led is marginal.

What's next

- **Section this week:** Build the MRR model spreadsheet and stress-test all three scenarios with your own assumptions
- **Reading:** "Week 8: The \$10K math" at </c/langobee-10k-mrr-26su/readings/wk08>
- **HW3 due this week.** Capstone "The \$10K MRR Operating Plan" goes out this week (due week 12).
- **Week 9:** Community-led distribution: Show HN, Reddit launch strategy, and measuring channel fit